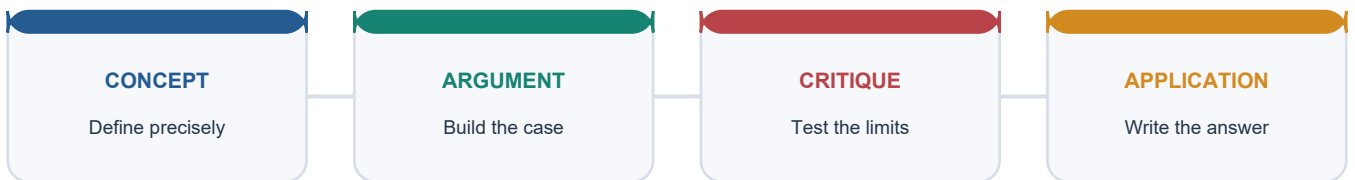


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 03 - Problem of Evil - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 7 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion 03 - Problem of Evil - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone workbook. It reproduces the complete practice apparatus of the Problem of Evil learning package and can be worked without the teaching sessions. Syllabus, verbatim: *Problem of Evil*. - UPSC Philosophy Paper II, Philosophy of Religion, item 3. □ The definition and coherence of each divine attribute belong to Notions of God, the positive arguments to Proofs for the Existence of God, rebirth mechanics and liberation to Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation, faith and properly basic belief to Reason, Revelation and Faith, and the sacred or holy as the object of religion to Religious Experience; they appear here only where a premise of this clause requires them. **Evidence discipline:** FACT: doctrine on which the standard sources converge · ANALYSIS: analytical reconstruction for exam use · CAUTION: a live scholarly dispute. Model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys; UPSC publishes no descriptive model answer for Philosophy Paper II, and Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so no objective question here is a previous-year question. **Terminology rule:** the English concept leads and the technical term follows immediately in parentheses - *privation of good (privatio boni)*, *unseen moral potency (adr̥ṣṭa)*, *karma-superintendent (karmādhyaṣa)*, *animal birth (tiryak-yoni)*, *imponderables (acinteyya)*, *beyond the senses (atīndriya)*, *suffering (duḥkha; Pali: dukkha)*, *ignorance (avidyā)*, *inflow of karmic matter (āsrava)*, *bondage (bandha)*, *purity and impurity (śuddhi/aśuddhi)*, *demerit and merit (pāpa/puṇya)*, *liberation (mokṣa/nirvāṇa/kaivalya)*, *empirical and ultimate levels (vyāvahārika/pāramārthika)*, *world-axis (axis mundi)*, *awe-inspiring and fascinating mystery (mysterium tremendum et fascinans)*. Provenance is examinable: the four-horn dilemma is transmitted by Lactantius, *De Ira Dei* 13, and traditionally ascribed to Epicurus; Augustine, *Enchiridion* and *City of God*; Leibniz, *Theodicee* (1710); Keats' journal-letter of spring 1819; Mackie, "Evil and Omnipotence", *Mind* (1955); Hick, *Evil and the God of Love* (1966); Plantinga, *God, Freedom, and Evil* (1974); Griffin, *God, Power, and Evil* (1976); Rowe (1979); Wykstra's CORNEA (1984); Hartshorne, *Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes* (1984); Adams, *Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God* (1999); Durkheim (1912); Otto (1917); Eliade (1957). No page, edition or invented quotation is attached to any of them.

What this workbook contains

Component	Count
Original diagnostic MCQs - 24 core plus 8 remedial drills	32
Question-specific option explanations	128
Unique examiner traps	32
Directly owned verified PYQs solved in full, 2019-2025	7
Original solved Mains models - two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks	6

How to use it

1. Attempt the twenty-four core MCQs without notes, then read every option explanation, including those for the options you rejected. The key sequence is **unpatterned** - each answer was fixed independently - so no cycle can be guessed, and option lengths are matched so the answer cannot be spotted by shape.
2. Work the eight remedial drills only after the core set. They target the confections and misattributions that cost marks on this clause every year: reply mismatched to version, the triad declared self-contradictory, privation read as denial of pain, soul-making reduced to a slogan, the process God called powerless, karma used to infer desert, the profane equated with the evil, and mystery substituted for CORNEA.
3. Attempt each previous-year part under time before reading its solution. **Decide the demanded structure from the directive first:** one part is functional-sociological, one asks for the logical problem, one is a paradox, two are quoted theses, one is a dependence claim and one is an enumeration of tenets.
4. Write the six original models in full. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 words, 15 marks about 240 to 260, 20 marks about 340 to 360.**

5. Check every answer against the four version-questions: which problem is being answered, what its burden is, which reply-type discharges that burden, and what the reply **costs**. A script that answers only the first has left most of the marks on the table.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

32 original MCQs - 24 core diagnostics and 8 remedial error-targeting drills

Philosophy Optional is examined only at the Mains stage, so **no question below is a Prelims previous-year question**. All thirty-two are original UPSC-style diagnostics written against this owner's doctrine.

Answer placement: each correct option was fixed **independently**, so the key sequence is unpatterned rather than rotated and no cycle such as ABCD - or its reverse - can be used to guess. Options are matched for length, specificity, grammar and visible formatting so that the answer cannot be spotted by shape alone. Every question carries four question-specific option explanations and one unique examiner trap.

Coverage: the twenty-four core questions run across the whole printed clause - *Problem of Evil* - covering the four versions of the problem and their burdens, the defence/theodicy distinction, the classification of evil, quotation and attribution discipline, Mackie's bridging premises and his adequate/fallacious framing, the paradox of omnipotence, Plantinga's free-will defence with transworld depravity, divine responsibility under absolute creation, Augustinian privation with the sin-and-punishment thesis and the inherited-guilt control, Hick's soul-making with epistemic distance and the Irenaean/Augustinian typology, concept-dependence, Rowe's evidential argument and its inductive step, Wykstra's CORNEA with the costs of skeptical theism, Adams' horrendous evils with balancing off versus defeat, animal and pre-human suffering, process theodicy with its named layers, the surrounding reply-space of greater-good, best-world, eschatological, mystery and anti-theodicy responses, the Indian karma frameworks across theistic and non-theistic schools, and evil and the profane as religion-forming categories. The eight remedial drills attack the errors that cost marks every year on this clause.

MCQ 1. Which version of the problem is on the table

A script answers a stem about the sheer quantity of undeserved suffering in the world by proving that God's existence and the existence of evil are not strictly contradictory. What has gone wrong?

- A. Nothing has gone wrong, because establishing logical consistency is sufficient to answer every formulation of the problem of evil.
- B. The script has answered the existential burden when the stem in fact raised the logical burden about a formal inconsistency.
- C. The script has answered the logical burden when the stem raised the evidential burden, where consistency does not restore probability.
- D. The script has confused moral with natural evil, which is a classificatory rather than a version-matching failure in this case.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: consistency answers Mackie alone, and Rowe explicitly grants consistency before pressing the improbability of divine permission.
- **B:** Incorrect: this inverts the two burdens, and the existential burden concerns whether a particular life can be a great good to the person living it.
- **C:** Correct: quantity and distribution belong to the evidential version, whose burden is probability, so a bare consistency proof leaves the charge standing.
- **D:** Incorrect: the classification of evil is a separate discipline, and the stem's fault here is the mismatch of reply-type to version rather than of kind.

Examiner trap 1: Candidates treat "the problem of evil" as one argument; the examiner treats it as four, and awards the first marks to whoever names the version in the opening two lines.

MCQ 2. What a defence claims and what a theodicy claims

Which statement states the difference between a defence and a theodicy correctly?

- A. A defence identifies God's actual reason for permitting evil, whereas a theodicy shows only that some such reason is logically available.
- B. A defence and a theodicy differ only in tone, the first being philosophical and the second devotional, but their success conditions are identical.
- C. A defence applies to natural evil while a theodicy applies to moral evil, so the two divide the field between them by subject matter.
- D. A defence shows that God could have a morally sufficient reason, whereas a theodicy claims to identify what that reason actually is.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this reverses the two, and it makes Plantinga's modest possibility claim into an assertion he explicitly declines to make.
- **B:** Incorrect: the success conditions differ sharply, since bare logical possibility suffices for a defence but never for a theodicy.
- **C:** Incorrect: the division is by claim-strength and not by subject matter, and both defences and theodicies address moral and natural evil.
- **D:** Correct: a defence discharges the consistency burden with a possible reason, while a theodicy asserts an actual reason and is refuted if that reason fails.

Examiner trap 2: Using "defence" and "theodicy" interchangeably caps a script at the average band, because the whole force of Plantinga's argument depends on his needing only possibility.

MCQ 3. Sorting the evil before selecting the reply

Consider the following statements about the classification of evil and the scope of the standard replies.

1. The free-will defence applies directly to moral evil and not directly to natural evil.
2. Hick's soul-making extends to natural evil by treating it as the environment of moral growth.
3. The free-will defence covers animal suffering because predation is a misuse of creaturely freedom.
4. Augustine reaches natural evil only by appealing to a fallen order, which is historically strained.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1, 2 and 4 only, because the scope of each reply is fixed by the kind of evil it was built to explain.
- B. 1 and 3 only, because freedom is the single source of all evil once creaturely agency is admitted.
- C. 2, 3 and 4 only, because natural and animal suffering are treated identically by every developmental theodicy.
- D. 1 and 2 only, because Augustine makes no attempt whatever to extend his account to natural evil.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: statements 1, 2 and 4 each state the scope of a reply accurately, and statement 3 fails because animals neither choose nor misuse freedom.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 3 is false, and the canonical rule is that answering animal suffering with the free-will defence is itself a marked error.
- **C:** Incorrect: statement 3 remains false, and soul-making covers animal suffering only instrumentally through human virtue toward animals.
- **D:** Incorrect: Augustine does extend the account to natural evil through the fallen order, which is why statement 4 belongs in the correct set.

Examiner trap 3: A script that writes "free will explains evil" without qualification has silently claimed to explain earthquakes, congenital disease and predation, and has invited the topic's commonest rejoinder.

MCQ 4. Attribution and quotation discipline in this clause

Which pairing of a formulation with its correct source is accurate?

- A. The four-horn dilemma is preserved in a surviving Epicurean treatise, and "the vale of Soul-making" was coined by Irenaeus in his image-and-likeness theology.
- B. The four-horn dilemma is reported by Lactantius, and "the vale of Soul-making" is Hick's own coinage in *Evil and the God of Love*.
- C. The four-horn dilemma reaches us through Lactantius, *De Ira Dei* 13, and "the vale of Soul-making" is John Keats's phrase from his spring 1819 journal-letter.
- D. The four-horn dilemma is Mackie's restatement in *Mind*, and "the vale of Soul-making" belongs to Chisholm's analysis of defeat and balancing off.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no surviving Epicurean text contains the dilemma, and Irenaeus supplies the image-and-likeness theology rather than the phrase itself.
- **B:** Incorrect: the Lactantius half is right, but Hick adopted an existing phrase and never presented it as his own invention.
- **C:** Correct: the dilemma is transmitted through Lactantius and traditionally ascribed to Epicurus, while Keats coined the phrase that Hick later borrowed.
- **D:** Incorrect: Mackie restates the logical problem rather than the dilemma, and Chisholm supplies the technical term "defeat" used by Adams.

Examiner trap 4: Attribution errors are cheap to avoid and expensive to make, because a misassigned phrase signals to the examiner that the doctrine behind it was never read.

MCQ 5. What actually makes Mackie's set inconsistent

Which statement identifies the role of the bridging premises correctly?

- A. The bridging premises are optional rhetorical devices, since "God is omnipotent", "God is perfectly good" and "evil exists" already entail a formal contradiction.
- B. Two additional principles are needed - that a good being eliminates evil as far as it can, and that omnipotence has no relevant limit on prevention.
- C. The bridging premises assert that evil is a positive substance, without which the set of propositions could not be brought into conflict at all.
- D. Only one bridging premise is required, namely that God's goodness must be recognisable to the creatures whose suffering is in question.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: nothing in the three propositions plus logic alone entails both a proposition and its negation, which is what formal contradiction requires.
- **B:** Correct: the goodness bridge and the power bridge together generate the inconsistency, and each is the target of a distinct family of theistic replies.
- **C:** Incorrect: the substantiality of evil is Augustine's target rather than Mackie's premise, and the set does not require it.
- **D:** Incorrect: recognisability is a separate hiddenness issue, and one bridge alone leaves the power side of the argument entirely unsupported.

Examiner trap 5: Declaring the triad self-contradictory and moving straight to free will concedes the analytical core of the 2020 question before the answer has properly begun.

MCQ 6. Mackie's own framing of the standard replies

In "Evil and Omnipotence" Mackie divides proposed solutions into adequate and fallacious ones. What is his criterion?

- A. An adequate solution abandons at least one of the disputed propositions, whereas a fallacious solution only appears to retain all of them.
- B. An adequate solution is one drawn from revealed theology, whereas a fallacious solution relies on philosophical reasoning alone about divine attributes.
- C. An adequate solution answers the evidential form of the argument, whereas a fallacious solution addresses only its weaker logical formulation.
- D. An adequate solution is accepted by most theists, whereas a fallacious solution has been abandoned by the mainstream theological tradition.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Mackie treats the honest exits as those that give up a proposition, and classifies replies that quietly limit power or redefine goodness as fallacious.
- **B:** Incorrect: revelation plays no part in Mackie's taxonomy, which is conducted entirely in terms of the consistency of a set of propositions.
- **C:** Incorrect: the evidential formulation postdates Mackie's article by more than two decades and is not what his classification is about.
- **D:** Incorrect: popularity is not a logical criterion, and Mackie's charge is precisely that widely held replies are among the fallacious ones.

Examiner trap 6: Naming Mackie's adequate/fallacious framing shows the examiner that the article was read rather than the slogan, and it costs one sentence to include.

MCQ 7. The paradox of omnipotence, stated as a dilemma

Which statement expresses Mackie's paradox of omnipotence most accurately?

- A. If God is omnipotent, God can perform logically contradictory tasks, and the impossibility of such tasks therefore disproves divine omnipotence outright.
- B. If God cannot make beings God cannot control, second-order power is limited; if God can and does, first-order power over them is limited.
- C. If God is omnipotent, God must intervene in every case of suffering, and the observed absence of intervention therefore establishes that God is not good.
- D. If God creates free beings, God thereby ceases to be omniscient about their future choices, which is the real limitation the paradox exposes.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: almost no theist claims omnipotence covers the self-contradictory, so this attacks a position that the debate does not actually contain.
- **B:** Correct: the paradox turns on the incompatibility of unrestricted first-order and second-order power, and each horn carries its own cost.
- **C:** Incorrect: this restates the goodness bridge of the logical problem rather than the paradox about the structure of power itself.
- **D:** Incorrect: the foreknowledge issue is a distinct problem, and Mackie's paradox concerns power over things rather than knowledge of them.

Examiner trap 7: Reducing the 2021 question to the heavy-stone puzzle produces a riddle rather than an analysis and leaves the required connection to evil entirely unmade.

MCQ 8. The premise structure of the free-will defence

Which reconstruction of Plantinga's free-will defence is correct?

- A. Significant freedom is a great good, it entails genuine alternatives, God cannot causally determine a free creature to choose only rightly, so moral evil is possible alongside perfect goodness.
- B. Significant freedom is a great good, God therefore creates only agents who will in fact choose rightly, and the moral evil we observe must accordingly be an illusion.
- C. Significant freedom is a great good, and since God foresees every misuse of it, God bears no responsibility for any consequence that follows from creaturely choice.
- D. Significant freedom is a great good, so God permits moral evil in order to produce the greater good of courage, compassion and mature moral character.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the defence's actual chain, and step three is the self-cancelling description that blocks a causally guaranteed world of only-right choices.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing in the defence denies the reality of moral evil, and denying it would abandon the proposition the argument is meant to accommodate.
- **C:** Incorrect: foreknowledge is a separate issue, and Plantinga does not argue that divine foresight discharges divine responsibility.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is Hick's developmental rationale rather than Plantinga's modal one, and it converts a defence into a theodicy.

Examiner trap 8: Blending Plantinga's modal argument with Hick's developmental one produces a hybrid that neither author holds and that no objection in the literature actually targets.

MCQ 9. The modal status of transworld depravity

What exactly does Plantinga claim about transworld depravity?

- A. That it is an empirically established feature of human psychology, confirmed by the observed frequency of wrongdoing in every known society.
- B. That it is a necessary truth about creaturely essences, so that no possible free creature could ever refrain from wrongdoing in any circumstance.
- C. That it is a theological doctrine equivalent to the Augustinian Fall, transmitted to every human being through inherited guilt from an ancestral act.
- D. That it is possibly true of every creaturely essence God could instantiate, which is enough to block Mackie's demand for only-good free agents.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the claim is modal rather than empirical, and Plantinga needs no evidence about actual human behaviour to make the defence work.
- **B:** Incorrect: necessity is far stronger than the argument requires, and Plantinga is careful not to assert that transworld depravity is even actual.
- **C:** Incorrect: the Augustinian Fall is a theological narrative about historical origin, whereas transworld depravity is a claim about possible worlds.
- **D:** Correct: possibility suffices for a defence, and that possibility is precisely what defeats the demand for a world of free agents who never go wrong.

Examiner trap 9: Attacking transworld depravity as empirically unsupported misses the modal point entirely and shows that the difference between defence and theodicy was never grasped.

MCQ 10. Absolute creation and the location of responsibility

The 2022 stem asserts that if God is the Absolute Creator, responsibility for evil cannot belong to the human agent. Which combination of replies is philosophically appropriate?

- A. God creates the capacity while the agent supplies the act; evil is a privation rather than a created thing; and foreknowledge does not amount to causation.
- B. God creates every act directly, so responsibility is genuinely divine, and the human agent is correctly described by the stem as a mere instrument.
- C. The stem is answered by pointing out that natural evil exists, since earthquakes show that not all suffering can be traced to any agent at all.
- D. The stem collapses because omnipotence is incoherent, so there is no Absolute Creator whose responsibility could be discussed in the first place.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these are the three standard replies about authorship, metaphysics and knowledge, and together they locate responsibility with the acting agent.
- **B:** Incorrect: conceding the stem outright abandons the critical directive, which asks for examination rather than acceptance of the claim.
- **C:** Incorrect: natural evil is outside the stem's scope, which concerns moral evil and the agency of the human being who commits it.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the process route, which changes the subject rather than examining the conditional the stem actually asserts.

Examiner trap 10: The strongest scripts concede the rejoinder - that knowingly instantiating the whole system remains morally relevant - instead of pretending the free-will reply closes the matter.

MCQ 11. What the privation account establishes

Which statement about Augustine's privation account is correct?

- A. It establishes that suffering is an illusion produced by a defective perspective, since what has no positive being can have no real effect on a creature.
- B. It establishes that evil has an independent creative source opposed to God, which is why the created order contains both good and evil substances.
- C. It establishes that God is the direct cause of natural evil while remaining the indirect cause of moral evil through the freedom given to creatures.
- D. It establishes that evil depends parasitically on good and has no created substance of its own, without thereby justifying any particular permitted deprivation.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a privation is a real lack in a subject that ought to possess the missing good, and blindness is not thereby rendered unreal.
- **B:** Incorrect: metaphysical dualism is exactly what the privation account is designed to avoid, since being as being is held to be good.
- **C:** Incorrect: the account denies that God creates evil at all, and it treats natural evil through the fallen order rather than direct causation.
- **D:** Correct: the account secures metaphysical economy and divine innocence in creation, while leaving the separate question of permission unanswered.

Examiner trap 11: The commonest misreading is that privation trivialises pain; a script that says so has attacked a position no serious Augustinian holds.

MCQ 12. The sin-and-punishment thesis and the inherited-guilt control

Which treatment of the 2023 thesis is philosophically strongest?

- A. Accept the thesis without qualification, since Augustine's authority settles the matter and the printed stem reproduces his considered position exactly.
- B. Reconstruct the thesis, then distinguish inherited personal guilt from an inherited damaged condition, and note that the second is more defensible but still owes an explanation.
- C. Reject the thesis immediately, since innocent suffering is obvious and no further reconstruction of Augustine's metaphysical framework is therefore required.
- D. Restate the thesis as a claim about natural law, since disease and disaster are the punishments that the sentence must have been intended to describe.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the directive is *critically discuss*, and unqualified acceptance forfeits the evaluative half of a twenty-mark question.
- **B:** Correct: the directive requires the system before the objection, and the guilt-versus-condition distinction is the sharpest available critical instrument.
- **C:** Incorrect: objecting before reconstruction breaches the directive and loses the marks reserved for faithful exposition of the author's position.
- **D:** Incorrect: this narrows the thesis to natural evil alone, whereas the sentence explicitly partitions all evil into sin and its punishment.

Examiner trap 12: Treat the printed sentence as the object of analysis rather than as a verified verbatim translation; the doctrine is Augustinian, but the exact wording is the examiner's, not a certified rendering.

MCQ 13. The three components of Hick's soul-making

Which set of elements is indispensable to Hick's theodicy?

- A. Retributive justice, a historical Fall, and the eventual restoration of an original perfection that human beings once actually possessed.
- B. Divine hiddenness as an end in itself, the denial of libertarian freedom, and a purely eschatological account of all present goods.
- C. The compensation of victims, the punishment of wrongdoers, and the proportioning of happiness to virtue within the present life.
- D. Genuine freedom, an epistemic distance from God that leaves the world religiously ambiguous, and a stable law-governed order that can injure.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: these are the Augustinian type's components, which Hick explicitly contrasts with the forward-looking Irenaean type he defends.
- **B:** Incorrect: epistemic distance serves freedom rather than being an end in itself, and Hick requires libertarian freedom rather than denying it.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is Kant's structure of the highest good, and soul-making is developmental rather than retributive or distributive.
- **D:** Correct: these three convert the platitude that hardship builds character into a theodicy with a stated rationale and a stated cost.

Examiner trap 13: Reducing Hick to "suffering makes us stronger" discards the three components that carry the argument and leaves nothing for an objection to engage with.

MCQ 14. Varying the God-concept

The 2024 stem claims that the problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system. Which treatment best fulfils the directive?

- A. Assert that all religions face the problem equally, since suffering is universal and no conceptual variation can alter the force of the argument.
- B. Deny the claim outright, since the reality of suffering is independent of theology and therefore cannot depend on any concept of the divine.
- C. Run the classical set against classical theism, a finite or process God, an impersonal Absolute and non-creator systems, and price each dissolution.
- D. Concede the claim and conclude that theism is refuted, since a problem that varies with the concept cannot be a genuine philosophical problem at all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: non-creator systems face no charge of divine culpability, so the claim of uniform force cannot survive a single comparative test.
- **B:** Incorrect: the reality of suffering is not in dispute; what varies is whether that suffering constitutes an objection to a given God-concept.
- **C:** Correct: showing the dependence requires varying the concept, and the critical half is naming the religiously significant loss each variation incurs.
- **D:** Incorrect: concept-dependence relocates the cost into the theology rather than refuting theism, and the theodicies exist precisely to keep all the attributes.

Examiner trap 14: Listing the dissolutions without their costs answers only half the 2024 question, because "critically discuss" buys the price list as much as the mechanism.

MCQ 15. The Irenaean and Augustinian types

Which contrast between Hick's two types is stated correctly?

- A. The Augustinian type is developmental and teleological, while the Irenaean type is retributive and explains suffering as deserved punishment for sin.
- B. The Augustinian type looks back to a fall from an original perfection, while the Irenaean type looks forward to growth from immaturity into likeness.
- C. The Augustinian type denies human freedom altogether, while the Irenaean type makes freedom the sole explanation of both moral and natural evil.
- D. The Augustinian type is a defence needing only possibility, while the Irenaean type is a theodicy claiming to identify God's actual purposes.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this reverses the two types and would make Irenaeus the source of the retributive framing that Hick contrasts with his own.
- **B:** Correct: the backward-looking Fall and the forward-looking image-to-likeness growth are exactly the axis on which Hick's typology turns.
- **C:** Incorrect: Augustine grounds moral evil in defective will, which presupposes rather than denies creaturely freedom.
- **D:** Incorrect: both are theodicies claiming actual reasons, and the defence category belongs to Plantinga and to skeptical theism instead.

Examiner trap 15: The typology is itself examinable content; naming it converts a list of theodicies into a structured account of how the tradition divides.

MCQ 16. Rowe's argument and its inductive step

Which statement about the evidential argument is correct?

- A. It is a deductive demonstration whose conclusion follows necessarily once the existence of any instance of intense suffering has been conceded.
- B. It concerns only moral evil, since natural suffering cannot be described as gratuitous in the absence of an agent who might have prevented it.
- C. It begins from the claim that some suffering serves no discernible justifying good, and its weakest point is the step from unseen reason to absent reason.
- D. It succeeds only if the theist grants that God's reasons must be transparent to human beings, which no classical theist has ever been willing to concede.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Rowe presents the argument as evidential rather than demonstrative, and he allows that a theist may remain rational in rejecting it.
- **B:** Incorrect: the fawn is a case of natural evil, and it was chosen precisely because no human agency is involved anywhere in it.
- **C:** Correct: the inductive step from "no justifying reason is seen" to "no justifying reason exists" is exactly what skeptical theism attacks.
- **D:** Incorrect: the argument requires only that such reasons would probably be discernible, which is weaker than a demand for full transparency.

Examiner trap 16: Presenting the fawn as a deductive contradiction collapses the logical and evidential versions and triggers the most heavily penalised error in this clause.

MCQ 17. Wykstra's condition, stated exactly

Which formulation states CORNEA correctly?

- A. One may claim that p is absent whenever no evidence for p has been produced, since the burden of proof always rests on the party asserting existence.
- B. One may claim that it appears that p is absent only if it is reasonable to believe that p would likely be discernible, given one's cognitive situation, were it there.
- C. One may claim that p is absent only if a competent authority within the relevant religious tradition has confirmed that no such thing has ever been observed.
- D. One may claim that p is absent only if the claim can be verified by a repeatable procedure, which no claim about divine purposes could ever satisfy.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is a generic burden-of-proof rule, whereas CORNEA is a specific condition on when an appearance of absence licenses a claim of absence.
- **B:** Correct: the Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access ties the legitimacy of a *noseeum* claim to the likelihood of discernment in one's actual cognitive position.
- **C:** Incorrect: appeals to religious authority form no part of Wykstra's epistemology, which is framed entirely in terms of cognitive access.
- **D:** Incorrect: a verificationist criterion would prove far too much and would also eliminate the theistic claims Wykstra is defending.

Examiner trap 17: Substituting "God works in mysterious ways" for a stated epistemic principle converts a defensible philosophical position into an unfalsifiable appeal worth no marks.

MCQ 18. What skeptical theism costs and what it covers

Consider the following statements about skeptical theism.

1. It is a defence rather than a theodicy, because it attacks an inference instead of identifying God's reason.
2. It targets the evidential argument rather than the logical problem.
3. Its principal cost is that the same scepticism threatens ordinary moral judgement and the duty to rescue.
4. It is refuted outright by the observation that we routinely infer absence from non-observation.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 4 only, because the inference from non-observation to absence is a standard and reliable form of everyday reasoning.
- B. 2, 3 and 4 only, because skeptical theism claims to state God's reasons while denying that we can identify them.
- C. 1 and 2 only, because the moral-scepticism objection was withdrawn once the scope restriction to value-entailments was proposed.
- D. 1, 2 and 3 only, because the *noseeum* inference is legitimate in some domains and CORNEA specifies exactly when it fails.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: statement 4 misstates the position, since CORNEA concedes that such inferences are often sound and specifies the condition under which they are not.
- **B:** Incorrect: statement 1 is dropped here even though it is true, and the description offered of skeptical theism contradicts its defensive character.
- **C:** Incorrect: the moral-scepticism objection has not been withdrawn, and critics find the value-entailment restriction unstable and *ad hoc*.
- **D:** Correct: the position is a defence against the evidential argument, and its standing price is the threat it poses to ordinary moral confidence.

Examiner trap 18: Deploying skeptical theism and a positive theodicy in the same paragraph is self-undermining, because one says the reason is unknowable while the other names it.

MCQ 19. Horrendous evils and the distinction that answers them

Which statement captures Adams' position accurately?

- A. A horrendous evil is any evil of exceptional magnitude, and it is answered by showing that the world's total value nevertheless exceeds its total disvalue.
- B. A horrendous evil is one caused by human cruelty rather than by nature, and it is answered by the free-will defence supplemented by eventual divine judgement.
- C. A horrendous evil gives the participant *prima facie* reason to doubt their life is a great good to them, and requires defeat within that life rather than global balancing.
- D. A horrendous evil is one for which no explanation is available, and it is answered by conceding that theodicy has failed and that only silence is appropriate.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: magnitude alone is not the criterion, and a global sum is precisely the response Adams argues cannot answer the person's own question.
- **B:** Incorrect: perpetrators as well as victims are participants, and the definition is fixed by the threat to a life's overall worth rather than by causal origin.
- **C:** Correct: the definition is technical and the required response is personal-level defeat, which Chisholm's term distinguishes from mere balancing off.

- **D:** Incorrect: Adams offers a positive account through divine identification and beatific intimacy rather than a concession that no answer exists.

Examiner trap 19: Using "horrendous evil" as a loose intensifier discards the one distinction - defeat within a life versus balancing across a world - that the term was coined to carry.

MCQ 20. Which replies survive the animal-suffering case

Which assessment of the pre-human suffering problem is correct?

- A. Free will and retribution fail immediately, soul-making applies only instrumentally through human virtue, and nomic regularity alone partly survives on the Western side.
- B. Soul-making succeeds completely, because the suffering animal acquires the virtues of endurance and patience that constitute moral growth in any sentient creature.
- C. The problem dissolves once we accept that animals lack sentience altogether, a position now settled by consensus in both philosophy and the empirical sciences.
- D. The problem is answered by the fallen-order reply, which is the historically and scientifically best-supported explanation of pre-human natural suffering.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the animal neither chooses nor morally grows, so only the stable-order reply retains any purchase, and even that explains kind rather than amount.
- **B:** Incorrect: moral growth requires an agent capable of freely chosen virtue, which is exactly what the animal sufferer is not.
- **C:** Incorrect: the neo-Cartesian premise about higher-order awareness is philosophically and empirically contested rather than settled.
- **D:** Incorrect: a cosmic fall preceding human history is historically and scientifically strained and is among the weakest replies available.

Examiner trap 20: Naming the animal case as the point where two major theodicies both run out is itself a mark-earning move, and omitting it leaves a twenty-marker without its residue paragraph.

MCQ 21. Process theodicy and its named layers

Which statement correctly assigns a claim to its process author?

- A. Whitehead argued that classical omnipotence is incoherent, Hartshorne introduced the initial aim, and Griffin coined the phrase "fellow-sufferer who understands".
- B. Whitehead supplied the dipolar God with primordial and consequent natures, Hartshorne argued omnipotence is incoherent, and Griffin made persuasion a metaphysical necessity.
- C. Whitehead defended a self-limiting God who chooses restraint, Hartshorne systematised the theology, and Griffin treated evil as privation of a due good.
- D. Whitehead denied that God has any nature at all, Hartshorne restored divine immutability, and Griffin argued that evil is necessary for the greater good.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the incoherence argument is Hartshorne's, the initial aim is Whitehead's, and the fellow-sufferer phrase closes *Process and Reality*.
- **B:** Correct: this assigns the dipolar structure, the incoherence argument and the metaphysical-necessity move to their actual authors.
- **C:** Incorrect: chosen self-limitation is Plantinga's structure rather than Whitehead's, and privation belongs to Augustine rather than to Griffin.

- **D:** Incorrect: the dipolar doctrine is Whitehead's own, and process thought explicitly rejects both immutability and the greater-good instrumentalisation of evil.

Examiner trap 21: Writing "process theodicy (Whitehead)" and stopping forfeits the marks reserved for naming which layer of the position is doing the work in the argument.

MCQ 22. The reply-space around the classical theodicies

Which pairing of a response with its principal cost is accurate?

- A. The Leibnizian best-world response costs nothing philosophically, because a perfect being must by definition select the unique optimum among possible worlds.
- B. Eschatological fulfilment costs nothing, since a later restoration automatically converts any permitted suffering into a justified means to that restoration.
- C. The greater-good and stable-order response may explain the *kind* of world without explaining the *amount* or *distribution* of suffering within it.
- D. Protest or anti-theodicy costs nothing, because refusing to justify suffering settles the logical and evidential arguments in the objector's favour at once.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: there may be no unique best world, and world-total optimisation can neglect goodness to the particular persons who bear the losses.
- **B:** Incorrect: compensation after suffering is not automatically justification for permitting it, which is exactly the balancing-versus-defeat point.
- **C:** Correct: risk and regular law can be shown necessary for certain goods without thereby accounting for the observed quantity or allocation of harm.
- **D:** Incorrect: protest diagnoses the ethics of explanation but leaves the logical and evidential arguments themselves entirely unsettled.

Examiner trap 22: Every response in this space has a stated cost; a script that lists responses without costs has described the literature instead of evaluating it.

MCQ 23. Karma across the Indian schools

Which statement about the Indian responses to suffering is correct?

- A. Mīmāṃsā, Buddhist and Jain accounts require no divine distributor, while Nyāya and theistic Vedānta assign God a just administrative role over karmic fruit.
- B. Every Indian school treats karma as administered by a personal creator God, which is why the Indian tradition faces the same problem of evil as classical theism.
- C. Karma is presented in all schools as a doctrine with an identifiable first act, since a beginningless series would make the assignment of desert impossible.
- D. Advaita denies that suffering occurs at all, and therefore has no need of any account of the empirical distribution of pain among embodied beings.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the theistic and non-theistic accounts differ precisely on whether a divine dispenser is required, and Nyāya's Lord allots according to desert rather than arbitrarily.
- **B:** Incorrect: the non-theistic schools drop the defendant entirely, which is the structural reason the Indian material can dissolve the classical problem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the series is standardly treated as beginningless, which blocks the demand for a first wrongful act without verifying any particular past cause.

- **D:** Incorrect: Advaita locates suffering at the empirical level and treats it as sublated only under liberating knowledge at the ultimate level.

Examiner trap 23: Presenting karma as a single theistic doctrine across the schools is the canonical error, and it also destroys the comparison that makes the Indian material worth citing.

MCQ 24. Evil and the profane as religion-forming categories

Which statement about the 2019 owner-module is correct?

- A. The profane is a synonym for the evil, so Durkheim's binary is a moral classification of actions into the permitted and the forbidden.
- B. Otto's holy and Durkheim's sacred are interchangeable terms, since both denote the social classification through which a moral community is constituted.
- C. Evil and the profane found religion structurally by supplying the predicament, the boundary, the institutions and the soteriological task.
- D. Eliade's hierophany describes the moral judgement by which a community declares certain acts sinful and therefore excludes them from communal life.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Durkheim's profane is simply the ordinary and non-consecrated, and conflating it with the wicked is the commonest error on this stem.
- **B:** Incorrect: Otto's numinous holy is the object-side of religious response, whereas Durkheim's sacred is a social classification.
- **C:** Correct: the four-step sequence is the functional account the directive demands, and it founds religion rather than theism.
- **D:** Incorrect: hierophany is the irruption of the sacred generating sacred space and time, not a moral verdict on conduct.

Examiner trap 24: Answering this functional-sociological stem with theodicies answers a different question, because the 2019 examiner asks what evil and the profane *do*, not whether they disprove God.

Remedial MCQs - common-error repair

These eight drills target the specific errors that the canonical trap list identifies as recurring on this clause. Attempt them only after the twenty-four core diagnostics.

MCQ 25. Repairing the mismatch of reply to version

A candidate answers a stem on the amount and distribution of suffering by reconstructing the free-will defence in full. Which correction is required?

- A. None; the free-will defence is the standard reply to every formulation, and its coverage of moral evil is sufficient for any stem on suffering.
- B. The candidate should have used the free-will defence but added a devotional conclusion, since an evidential stem calls for pastoral rather than analytic treatment.
- C. The candidate should have replaced the free-will defence with the Augustinian privation account, which alone addresses the quantity of suffering in the world.
- D. The candidate should have named the evidential version and answered with a theodicy, skeptical theism or a revised God-concept rather than a bare consistency defence.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the defence answers only the logical charge, and the amount of suffering is untouched by any argument that establishes bare possibility.
- **B:** Incorrect: a devotional conclusion is penalised at every band, and the fault here is structural rather than one of tone.
- **C:** Incorrect: privation addresses the metaphysical status of evil rather than its quantity, so the substitution repairs nothing.
- **D:** Correct: the evidential burden is probability, and only a positive reason, a blocked inference or a changed God-concept can discharge it.

Examiner trap 25: Version-mismatch is invisible to the candidate and obvious to the examiner, which is why naming the version explicitly in the opening is worth more than any additional content.

MCQ 26. Repairing "the triad is self-contradictory on its face"

A script asserts that omnipotence, perfect goodness and the existence of evil are contradictory without further argument. What must be supplied?

- A. A definition of evil as a positive substance, since only a substantial evil could stand in genuine logical opposition to divine goodness.
- B. The two bridging principles about what a good being does and what an omnipotent being can do, without which no formal contradiction arises.
- C. An empirical survey of the quantity of suffering, since the contradiction emerges only once the scale of the world's evil is established.
- D. A demonstration that God's goodness must be recognisable to creatures, since an unrecognisable goodness could not conflict with anything observable.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: substantiality is Augustine's target rather than a requirement of Mackie's argument, which is about the consistency of propositions.
- **B:** Correct: the goodness and power bridges convert a merely uncomfortable set into an inconsistent one, and each is separately contestable.
- **C:** Incorrect: quantity belongs to the evidential version, and the logical charge is meant to hold even for a single instance of evil.
- **D:** Incorrect: recognisability concerns divine hiddenness, which is a distinct issue and no part of the logical formulation.

Examiner trap 26: The 2020 stem is answered in the bridges; a script that omits them has written the question's premise rather than its answer.

MCQ 27. Repairing "privation means the pain is not real"

A script argues that because Augustine calls evil a privation, Augustinian theodicy denies the reality of suffering. What is the correct repair?

- A. The script is right, and this is precisely why the privation account was abandoned by later Christian theology in favour of the Irenaean approach.
- B. The script should add that privation applies only to moral evil, so that natural suffering remains fully real while moral evil is merely an absence.
- C. The script should recognise that a privation is a real lack of a good that ought to be present, so blindness is a determinate deprivation rather than an illusion.
- D. The script should replace privation with the process account, since only a God of persuasive power can take the reality of suffering seriously.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the account was not abandoned, and its central claim concerns the metaphysical status of evil rather than the phenomenology of pain.
- **B:** Incorrect: privation is not restricted to moral evil, and the proposed split has no basis in the Augustinian framework.
- **C:** Correct: the account denies evil an independent substance while affirming that the lack is real in a subject whose nature calls for the missing good.
- **D:** Incorrect: substituting a different theodicy avoids the misreading instead of correcting it, and the question asks for a repair.

Examiner trap 27: Rot in wood is the canonical illustration: the rot is not a rival substance, and it is not therefore imaginary - it is the real loss of the wood's proper integrity.

MCQ 28. Repairing "soul-making just means suffering makes us stronger"

Which repair restores Hick's argument?

- A. Add epistemic distance, genuine freedom and a stable law-governed order, and distinguish the developmental rationale from retributive punishment.
- B. Add the claim that every instance of suffering produces a proportionate increase in virtue, which is what makes the theodicy explanatorily complete.
- C. Add the claim that Irenaeus coined the phrase "vale of Soul-making", which supplies the patristic authority the modern version otherwise lacks.
- D. Add the observation that soul-making covers animal suffering directly, since animals also develop resilience through the hardships they endure.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these three components convert a platitude into a theodicy with a rationale, and the contrast with punishment fixes its forward-looking character.
- **B:** Incorrect: Hick makes no proportionality claim, and asserting one exposes the theodicy to the scale objection in its strongest form.
- **C:** Incorrect: the phrase is Keats's from the spring 1819 journal-letter, and attributing it to Irenaeus is a marked factual error.
- **D:** Incorrect: the animal does not morally grow, so extended soul-making reaches animals only instrumentally through human virtue toward them.

Examiner trap 28: Keats supplied the phrase, Irenaeus the image-and-likeness theology and Hick the modern theodicy; collapsing the three is the single commonest attribution error in this topic.

MCQ 29. Repairing "the process God is simply powerless"

Which statement corrects the misdescription?

- A. The process God possesses full classical omnipotence but voluntarily declines to use it, which is why evil occurs without divine culpability.
- B. The process God has no relation to the world at all, so questions of power and culpability do not arise within the process framework.
- C. The process God is powerless in the strict sense, and process writers accept that this makes their deity unworthy of worship by their own admission.
- D. The process God exercises persuasive power by supplying each occasion its initial aim, and cannot coerce because to be actual is to have some self-determination.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: voluntary restraint is Plantinga's structure, whereas Griffin's point is that the limitation is metaphysically necessary rather than chosen.
- **B:** Incorrect: the consequent nature makes God supremely related to the world, which is the opposite of detachment.
- **C:** Incorrect: the worship objection is raised by critics and answered by appeal to solidarity and objective immortality, not conceded by process writers.
- **D:** Correct: persuasion through the initial aim is a real and maximal form of power, limited by the distributed self-determination of actual entities.

Examiner trap 29: The modal difference is the examinable point: Griffin's God *cannot* coerce, while Plantinga's God *chooses* not to intervene.

MCQ 30. Repairing "karma shows that this person deserved it"

A script infers from a person's suffering that they must have committed a specific wrong in a previous life. What is the correct repair?

- A. The inference is unavailable to ordinary observers, and using karma this way converts explanation into victim-blaming without any epistemic warrant.
- B. The inference is sound but should be stated compassionately, since the doctrine's truth is unaffected by the distress that stating it may cause.
- C. The inference is valid only in theistic schools, where a divine dispenser guarantees that each specific suffering matches a specific past act.
- D. The inference should be replaced by the claim that suffering is illusory, which is the Advaitic solution to the difficulty the script has created.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the mechanism is not observationally accessible, so no particular desert can be read off a particular case, and the misuse is a moral as well as epistemic error.
- **B:** Incorrect: the inference is not sound, and presenting an unwarranted judgement gently does not make it warranted.
- **C:** Incorrect: even where God allots fruit justly, the specific karmic history remains beyond the senses and known only through testimony.
- **D:** Incorrect: Advaita places suffering at the empirical level rather than denying it, and the substitution introduces a second error.

Examiner trap 30: Karma does not cancel present duties of compassion, protection and relief; a causal explanation is never moral permission to withhold aid, and saying so protects the answer's ethical credibility.

MCQ 31. Repairing "the profane is the evil"

A script treating the 2019 stem writes that the profane is the wicked and the sacred the righteous. What is the correct repair?

- A. Replace the pair with the pure and impure, since ritual pollution is the only category that Durkheim's sociology actually recognises.
- B. Distinguish four categories - evil as moral or natural harm, the profane as the ordinary, the impure as the ritually polluting and the demonic as the anti-sacred.
- C. Replace Durkheim with Otto, since only the numinous account of the holy can supply the moral content that the sacred-profane binary lacks.
- D. Retain the identification but restrict it to Indian traditions, where purity codes make the profane and the morally wrong effectively equivalent.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the impure is one further category rather than a replacement, and Durkheim's classification is explicitly of things into sacred and profane.
- **B:** Correct: keeping the four apart is what the module requires, and the profane is the everyday rather than the wicked.
- **C:** Incorrect: Otto describes the object-side of religious response and does not supply a moral content to Durkheim's social classification.
- **D:** Incorrect: Indian purity and impurity codes are ritual categories, and demerit and merit form a separate moral vocabulary alongside them.

Examiner trap 31: A ploughed field, a market and an ordinary weekday are all profane and none of them is evil; one such illustration in the opening paragraph prevents the whole error.

MCQ 32. Repairing "God's ways are mysterious" as a philosophical position

A script offers divine mystery as its answer to the evidential argument. What is the correct repair?

- A. Replace mystery with the free-will defence, since a defence is always preferable to a theodicy when the burden is one of probability.
- B. Retain mystery and add that it is unfalsifiable, since unfalsifiability protects the claim from any possible empirical objection.
- C. Replace mystery with a full theodicy, because any appeal to human cognitive limitation is illegitimate in philosophical argument.
- D. State CORNEA or Bergmann's representativeness theses, which give the appeal to limitation a disciplined form and a stated cost.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the free-will defence discharges the consistency burden and leaves the probability burden exactly where the script found it.
- **B:** Incorrect: unfalsifiability is a cost rather than a protection, and it is one of the three standing objections to skeptical theism.
- **C:** Incorrect: appeals to cognitive limitation are legitimate when disciplined by an access principle, which is precisely what CORNEA supplies.
- **D:** Correct: skeptical theism is the disciplined evidential version of the mystery appeal, and stating its principle also obliges the script to state its price.

Examiner trap 32: Without an access principle, mystery is an unfalsifiable appeal; with CORNEA it becomes a position that can be argued, graded and - importantly for the examiner - costed.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved conceptual drills and distinction loops

Five short drills that fix the distinctions the examiner tests before any full answer is attempted.

Drill 1 - Defence or theodicy? Plantinga offers a **defence**: he claims only that a morally sufficient reason is *possible*, so no evidence for transworld depravity is required. Hick offers a **theodicy**: he claims to identify God's *actual* purpose, and is therefore refuted if soul-making is not in fact the purpose.

Drill 2 - Explanation or justification? Karma *explains* why this person suffers by locating a cause; it does not thereby *justify* the suffering or license withholding aid. Confusing the two is how an explanatory doctrine becomes victim-blaming.

Drill 3 - Privation or illusion? Privation says evil is a real lack of a due good, not a created substance. Blindness is a determinate deprivation in a creature whose nature calls for sight; it is not an illusion, and Augustine never says it is.

Drill 4 - Balancing off or defeat? Balancing off outweighs the evil within a larger sum, leaving it external to the good. Defeat - Chisholm's term - integrates the evil into a whole whose value it contributes to. Adams demands the second, and demands it *within the individual life*.

Drill 5 - Skeptical theism or positive theodicy? Skeptical theism says we cannot tell whether a justifying reason exists. A theodicy says what the reason is. Holding both in the same paragraph is self-undermining, and the examiner notices.

All 7 verified owner PYQs - exact wording, year and marks

All 7 items below are direct verified owner PYQs. Exact wording, years and marks are retained. Demand decoding, full model solutions, marks rationale, timing skeletons and examiner traps are pedagogic answer support, not an official answer key.

Corpus note: FACT: The audited Paper II corpus for 2018-2025 contains **7 primary-owned question-parts** for this syllabus item, out of 112 parts overall. The clause owns no part in 2018 and exactly one part in every paper from 2019 through 2025. Cross-linked questions owned by *Notions of God, Soul, Immortality, Rebirth and Liberation or Religious Experience* are not duplicated here.

#	Year	Q	Marks	Theme
1	2019	Q6(b)	15	Evil and the profane as religion-forming categories
2	2020	Q6(b)	15	The logical problem of evil
3	2021	Q5(e)	10	The paradox of omnipotence in the context of evil
4	2022	Q6(c)	15	Absolute creation and human responsibility
5	2023	Q8(a)	20	Augustine - all evil is sin or punishment for sin
6	2024	Q6(c)	15	The problem as an offshoot of the God-concept
7	2025	Q6(b)	15	The main tenets of process theodicy

PYQ 1 - 2019, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"What role do the concepts of evil and profane play to provide a firm foundation to religion?"

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>What role do A and B play to provide a firm foundation to...</i> - a functional account of how negative categories constitute religion, not a definition of either term
Core issue	Whether religion is founded on a diagnosis of what is wrong rather than on belief in God
Scope boundary	This is the sociological-phenomenological question; the theistic problem of evil is not what is asked
Ideal thesis	Evil and the profane found religion structurally rather than doctrinally - and they found <i>religion</i> , not <i>theism</i>
Non-negotiables	Durkheim, Otto and Eliade correctly distinguished; the profane ≠ evil correction; the four-step founding sequence; Indian parity with its rider

Model answer (≈250 words)

The question is functional, not theological: it asks what work negative categories do in constituting religion. **Durkheim**, in *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life* (1912), holds that all known religious beliefs presuppose a classification of all things into two opposed classes, **profane** and **sacred**, and defines religion as a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, uniting adherents into a single moral community, a church. The definition is deliberately God-free. ANALYSIS: A correction must be made at once: the **profane is the ordinary, not the wicked**; evil, impurity and the demonic are three further and distinct categories.

Otto's *The Idea of the Holy* (1917) supplies the object-side - the **numinous**, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans* - while **Eliade's** *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957) shows the sacred irrupting as **hierophany**, generating sacred space around an *axis mundi* and recoverable sacred time.

The founding sequence follows. A religion first names a **predicament** - sin, impurity, suffering (*duḥkha*), ignorance (*avidyā*), karmic bondage. The predicament is marked by a **boundary** - pure and impure, sacred and profane - which generates ritual, prohibition and moral code. The boundary generates **institutions**: priesthood, initiation, purification, penance. The predicament generates a **soteriology**, the ordered path out.

Indian material is the clearest case: the Buddhist **First Noble Truth** makes suffering the explicit foundation of an entire religion; Jain *āsrava* and *bandha* name the predicament and *saṃvara* and *nirjarā* the exit. ANALYSIS: India's founding defect is more often ignorance or bondage than moral evil, which yields diagnosis-and-insight rather than sin-and-forgiveness.

Verdict: the binary is an ideal type, not a law, and wonder and gratitude are independent religious roots; but evil and the profane found religion **structurally** - they supply the predicament and the boundary without which soteriology would be idle. They found religion, not theism.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** functional framing -> Durkheim with the profane correction -> Otto and Eliade -> four-step sequence -> Indian parity -> ideal-type qualification -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** sacred/profane classification; the God-free definition of religion; the numinous; hierophany, *axis mundi*, recoverable time.
- **Distinction:** evil ≠ profane ≠ impure ≠ demonic, made in the first paragraph rather than as an afterthought.
- **Comparison:** the Buddhist First Noble Truth as the world's clearest case of evil as religion-founding.
- **Technical terms:** *duḥkha*, *avidyā*, *āsrava*, *bandha*, *saṃvara*, *nirjarā*, *mysterium tremendum et fascinans*.
- **Criticism:** the binary is a Durkheimian imposition and Eliade's archaic ontology is unfalsifiable; treat the pair as an ideal type.
- **Conclusion:** the structural-not-doctrinal verdict, plus the religion-not-theism rider that shows the candidate knows the question's scope.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Frame the question as functional, not theological
3 min : Durkheim + the profane ≠ evil correction
3 min : Otto (object-side) and Eliade (hierophany, space, time)
4 min : Predicament → boundary → institution → soteriology
2 min : Indian parity + the ignorance-not-sin rider
1 min : Ideal-type qualification; wonder and gratitude
1 min : Verdict - structural, not doctrinal; religion, not theism
Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Equating the profane with the evil: **the single commonest and most heavily penalised error on this stem.**
- Answering with theodicies: **out of scope; the question is functional.**
- Interchanging Otto's holy with Durkheim's sacred: **factual error about which side of the analysis each occupies.**
- Omitting Indian parity: **loses the comparative marks the paper reliably rewards.**
- Presenting the binary as a universal law: **ignores the standing objection that many traditions grade rather than dichotomise.**
- Concluding that evil founds theism: **the wrong conclusion; it founds religion, including non-theistic religion.**

PYQ 2 - 2020, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"What is the logical problem of evil? Discuss."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>What is... Discuss</i> - state the set precisely, then evaluate; a lament about suffering earns nothing
Core issue	Whether the theist's propositions are <i>formally</i> inconsistent
Scope boundary	The logical version only; the evidential problem appears at the end as the place the debate migrates to
Ideal thesis	The set is inconsistent only with the bridging premises , and the whole debate is a fight over those premises
Non-negotiables	Mackie 1955; the numbered set including omniscience; both bridges; adequate/fallacious framing; Plantinga's defence; the migration to Rowe

Model answer (~255 words)

The logical problem alleges that a set of theistic beliefs cannot all be true. **J. L. Mackie**, "Evil and Omnipotence" (*Mind*, 1955), sets out the propositions: God is **omnipotent**; God is **perfectly good**; and **evil exists**. The full classical profile adds **omniscience**, which blocks the reply that evil escaped divine notice.

Crucially, these propositions are **not formally contradictory by themselves**. Nothing in them, plus logic alone, entails both a proposition and its negation. The contradiction is manufactured by two **bridging principles**: first, that a perfectly good being eliminates evil as far as it can; second, that an omnipotent being has no relevant limit on preventing any evil whose prevention is logically possible. Mackie sorts the replies into **adequate solutions**, which honestly abandon one proposition, and **fallacious solutions**, which appear to keep all three while covertly limiting power or redefining goodness.

The theist has three exits, each attacking a bridge. Insert "**unless there is a morally sufficient reason**" into the goodness bridge, and the whole space of defences and theodicies opens. Deny the power bridge and one gets **Plantinga's free-will defence**: significant freedom entails genuine alternatives, God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose only rightly, so a world containing moral good may be unavailable without moral evil. Plantinga needs only **possibility**, which is why transworld depravity is asserted as possible and never as actual. Denying the reality of evil - privation, or the empirical level in Advaita - is the third and most costly exit.

Verdict: the logical problem is widely regarded as answered; the live debate has migrated to **Rowe's evidential** form, where consistency no longer suffices.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** numbered set -> why it is not a formal contradiction -> the two bridges -> the three exits -> verdict and migration.
- **Doctrine:** Mackie's article and date; the adequate/fallacious taxonomy; omniscience in the full profile.
- **Argument:** the bridges are written as separate premises, so the objections have something determinate to attack.
- **Distinction:** defence versus theodicy, deployed to explain why possibility suffices for Plantinga.
- **Technical terms:** inconsistent set, bridging premise, morally sufficient reason, transworld depravity.
- **Criticism:** the third exit's cost - denying evil's reality - is stated rather than passed over.
- **Conclusion:** naming the migration to the evidential problem is the highest-value sentence available in this question.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Define the logical problem as a consistency charge
 3 min : The propositions as a numbered set, including omniscience
 3 min : Why the bare set is not a formal contradiction
 3 min : Bridge A and Bridge B, written out
 3 min : Three exits - morally sufficient reason, Plantinga, privation/levels
 1 min : Mackie's adequate/fallacious framing
 1 min : Verdict - answered; the debate migrates to Rowe
 Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Asserting contradiction without the bridges: **concedes the analytical core of the question.**
- Confusing Mackie's charge with Rowe's: **version error, the most penalised fault in this clause.**
- Writing that Mackie "proved God does not exist": **overstatement; he argued a set is inconsistent.**
- Omitting omniscience: **leaves the ignorance reply open and weakens the profile.**
- Presenting Plantinga as supplying God's actual reason: **misdescribes a defence as a theodicy.**
- Ending without the migration: **loses the one sentence that shows command of the current debate.**

PYQ 3 - 2021, Q5(e), 10 marks

Exact question

"Discuss the paradox of omnipotence of God in the context of the existence of evil."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Discuss the paradox of...</i> - a paradox stated as a dilemma with both horns and both costs , then the restriction that dissolves it
Core issue	Whether unrestricted power over things and unrestricted power over what powers exist can coexist
Scope boundary	The context clause is mandatory: the paradox must be connected to evil, not discussed in the abstract
Ideal thesis	Unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is incoherent, and the free-will defence requires the restriction
Non-negotiables	Mackie 1955; first-order and second-order power; the three restrictions; the Plantinga/Griffin modal contrast

Model answer (≈160 words)

Mackie (*Mind*, 1955) frames the paradox as a dilemma: can an omnipotent being create things it cannot afterwards control? If it **cannot**, its **second-order** power - power to determine what powers exist - is limited. If it **can and does**, its **first-order** power over those things is limited. Unrestricted omnipotence in both senses is therefore incoherent.

Three restrictions dissolve it. Omnipotence may extend only to the **logically possible**, which almost all theists concede. Or it may be **second-order sovereignty freely self-bound** in the act of creating free agents. Or it may be abandoned, as in **process theism**, where power is intrinsically distributed and divine power is persuasive by metaphysical necessity.

The connection to evil is exact. The **free-will defence** requires one of these restrictions: God creates significantly free agents and cannot causally guarantee that they choose well. For Plantinga this restraint is **chosen**; for Griffin it is **metaphysically necessary**.

Verdict: the paradox does not refute theism; it forces theism to specify which sense of omnipotence it is defending, and to pay for the choice.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** dilemma -> both horns with costs -> three restrictions -> the link to evil -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the first-order/second-order distinction, which is the paradox's actual content.
- **Argument:** each horn is priced rather than merely stated.
- **Distinction:** chosen self-limitation versus metaphysical necessity, named with their authors.
- **Technical terms:** second-order sovereignty, self-binding, logically possible, persuasive power.
- **Criticism:** the self-binding route re-opens the intervention question, which the verdict acknowledges.
- **Conclusion:** the paradox forces a specification rather than a refutation - the correctly graded ending for ten marks.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : State the dilemma in one sentence
 2 min : Horn 1 and Horn 2, each with its cost
 3 min : The three restrictions, with the process option last
 2 min : The link to evil via the free-will defence
 1 min : Plantinga chooses; Griffin cannot
 1 min : Verdict - specification, not refutation
 Total : 10 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Using only the heavy-stone form: **a riddle rather than an analysis**.
- Omitting the connection to evil: **the stem's context clause is explicit and its omission is penalised**.
- Claiming the paradox disproves God: **overstatement; it shows an incoherence in one construal**.
- Merging Plantinga's chosen restraint with Griffin's necessity: **conflates a defence with a theodicy**.
- Drifting into the general coherence of omnipotence: **that belongs to Notions of God**.
- Exceeding the band: **a ten-marker with four theodicies has no analysis left in it**.

PYQ 4 - 2022, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"If God is the Absolute Creator, then the responsibility of the evil cannot belong to the human agent. Critically examine."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine [a quoted thesis]</i> - fidelity to the claim's scope before evaluation
Core issue	Whether absolute creation transfers moral authorship from the creature to the creator
Scope boundary	The stem concerns moral evil and human agency; natural evil is the residue, not the subject
Ideal thesis	The conditional fails as stated, but its rejoinder - that knowingly instantiating the system remains morally relevant - survives
Non-negotiables	Free-will defence; privation; foreknowledge ≠ causation; the process alternative; the retained rejoinder

Model answer (≈255 words)

The stem asserts a conditional: absolute creation entails that human agents cannot be responsible for evil. Its scope must be fixed first - it concerns **moral evil**, since no one attributes an earthquake to a human agent.

Three replies resist the conditional. First, the **free-will defence**: God creates the *capacity* for choice, while the agent supplies the *act*. Significant freedom entails genuine alternatives, and God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose rightly - the description cancels itself. A world of programmed beneficence lacks the moral authorship of a world containing genuinely responsible agents. Second, **Augustine's privation account**: God creates natures, all of which are good as created; evil is a **privation of a due good** arising in a **defective will**, so what God creates and what goes wrong are not the same item. Third, **foreknowledge is not causation**: knowing what an agent will freely do does not make the agent do it.

A fourth route rejects the antecedent. **Process theism** denies that God has the unilateral power the stem presupposes: power is intrinsically distributed, so no being determines another's becoming.

ANALYSIS: The critical half must concede what survives. Even granting that God does not cause the act, **knowingly choosing to instantiate the whole system, foreseeing its outcomes, remains morally relevant**. Foreknowledge does not cause free action, but it does not discharge the decision to create.

Verdict: the conditional is false as stated - creaturely authorship is preserved - but it is not empty. It correctly identifies a residual divine responsibility for the *system*, which the free-will defence answers by pricing rather than by denying.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: fix the scope -> three replies to the conditional -> one reply rejecting the antecedent -> the retained rejoinder -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine**: capacity versus act; *privatio boni*; the self-cancelling description of determined freedom.
- **Argument**: each reply is attached to the exact step of the conditional it blocks.
- **Distinction**: causing an act versus instantiating a system in which the act occurs.
- **Technical terms**: significant freedom, defective will, privation, unilateral power.
- **Criticism**: the rejoinder is conceded rather than suppressed, which is what "critically" buys.
- **Conclusion**: false as stated but not empty - a graded verdict rather than a flat rejection.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Fix the scope - moral evil, human agency
4 min : Free-will defence: capacity vs act; the self-cancelling description
3 min : Privation: God creates natures, not defects
2 min : Foreknowledge is not causation
2 min : Process denial of the antecedent
2 min : The retained rejoinder about instantiating the system
1 min : Verdict - false as stated, not empty
Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Accepting the conditional: **abandons the critical directive**.
- Answering with natural evil: **out of scope; the stem is about human agency**.
- Suppressing the rejoinder: **produces an uncritical defence and caps the script below the strong band**.
- Treating foreknowledge as the whole issue: **the stem is about creation, not omniscience**.
- Using the process reply as the only answer: **changes the subject rather than examining the claim**.
- Ending with a devotional sentence: **penalised at every band on this clause**.

PYQ 5 - 2023, Q8(a), 20 marks

Exact question

"All evil is either sin or punishment for sin." - St. Augustine. Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	"Quotation." - Critically discuss - reconstruct the author's own system first , then test it
Core issue	Whether the sin-and-punishment partition covers all evil
Scope boundary	Augustine's framework in full, then the standing objections; rivals appear as comparators, not as substitutes
Ideal thesis	The thesis preserves divine goodness for moral evil but is incomplete for natural, innocent and animal suffering
Non-negotiables	Privation metaphysics; defective will; the Fall; the guilt-versus-condition distinction; Hick and karma as comparators; CAUTION: status of the printed wording

Model answer (≈350 words)

Augustine's sentence partitions all evil into **sin** and its **punishment**. The metaphysics behind it must be stated before it is tested. Being, insofar as it is being, is **good**; God creates beings, not evil substances; corruption is **parasitic**, depending on a good nature to corrupt; and moral fault is **disordered willing**. Evil is therefore **privation of a due good (privatio boni)**, not a rival creative principle. ANALYSIS: Privation does not make pain unreal: rot is not a rival substance to wood but the real loss of the wood's proper integrity, and blindness is a determinate lack in a creature whose nature calls for sight.

On this basis the partition works as follows. **Moral evil is sin** - the misuse of created freedom. **Natural evil is punishment** - the consequence of a fallen, disordered order following the Fall.

The critical half has four parts. First, **innocent suffering**: infants and the congenitally afflicted fit a retributive reading poorly. Second, **animal and pre-human suffering**: no free-will defence and no retributive account applies to a creature that neither chooses nor sins, and CAUTION: a cosmic fall preceding human history is historically and scientifically strained. Third, **the metaphysics of privation** is strained for intense positive pain, which does not feel like an absence. Fourth, and most sharply, **inherited guilt**: the claim that later persons are *personally guilty* for an ancestor's act is far harder to defend than the claim that they inherit a **damaged condition** and a disordered social-natural order. ANALYSIS: The second reading reduces the objection but still owes an account of why a good creator permits the condition and its unequal effects.

Two comparators sharpen the verdict. **Hick's soul-making** replaces punishment with **development**: humans are created immature, at an epistemic distance, in a law-governed world where courage and compassion become possible. **Indian karma** replaces a single Fall with a **beginningless** series and thereby answers the **distribution** question - why *this* person - that Augustine cannot; its own cost is unverifiability and the risk of victim-blaming.

Verdict: treating the printed sentence as the object of analysis rather than as a certified translation CAUTION:, the thesis succeeds for moral evil and preserves divine goodness in creation, but it is incomplete for natural, innocent and animal suffering, where a developmental or distributional account does more work.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure**: metaphysics first -> the partition -> four objections -> two comparators -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine**: convertibility of being and goodness; parasitic corruption; defective will; the Fall.
- **Argument**: the partition is derived from the metaphysics rather than asserted alongside it.
- **Distinction**: inherited guilt versus inherited condition - the sharpest available critical instrument on this stem.
- **Technical terms**: *privatio boni*, disordered willing, epistemic distance, beginninglessness.
- **Comparison**: Hick on development and karma on distribution, each with its own cost stated.
- **Conclusion**: success-with-remainder rather than flat refutation, plus the quotation-discipline note.

Compact skeleton and timing

2 min : State the thesis and announce the reconstruct-then-test order
5 min : Privation metaphysics as four premises + rot/blindness examples
3 min : The partition: sin and punishment
5 min : Four objections - innocence, animals, strained privation, inherited guilt
3 min : Hick on development; karma on distribution, each with cost
2 min : Verdict + quotation-discipline note
Total : 20 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Objecting before reconstructing: **breaches the directive and forfeits the exposition marks.**
- Saying privation makes pain imaginary: **attacks a position no Augustinian holds.**
- Treating the printed sentence as a certified verbatim translation: **overstates the textual claim.**
- Merging inherited guilt with inherited condition: **loses the sharpest critical distinction available.**
- Omitting animal suffering: **the residue the examiner expects in a twenty-marker.**
- Concluding that Augustine simply fails: **ungraded verdict; the correct finding is success-with-remainder.**

PYQ 6 - 2024, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact question

"The problem of evil is a direct offshoot of how God is conceptualised in a system." Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically discuss</i> a thesis about dependence - show the dependence by varying the God-concept, then price each variation
Core issue	Whether the argument's force is fixed by the concept of God under defence
Scope boundary	Four God-concepts, not a survey of every theodicy; the theodicies enter as the attempt to keep all attributes
Ideal thesis	The claim is correct, but concept-dependence is not a solution: it relocates the cost into the theology
Non-negotiables	The classical set; process/finite God; Advaita's levels; non-creator systems; the cost of each dissolution

Model answer (≈255 words)

The thesis is correct, and its demonstration is straightforward. State the classical set: God is **omnipotent**, **omniscient**, **perfectly good** and **creator**, and evil exists; the contradiction requires the bridging principles that a good being eliminates evil as far as it can and that omnipotence has no relevant limit. The argument bites only where all four attributes are held together.

Now vary the concept. Weaken **omnipotence** and the **process** God, whose power is persuasive by metaphysical necessity, is simply not the kind of being who could have prevented the evil unilaterally - the charge lapses. Weaken **personality** and **Advaita's nirguṇa** Brahman is untouched: evil is real at the empirical level (*vyāvahārika*) and sublated under liberating knowledge at the ultimate level (*pāramārthika*). Remove the **creator** and Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā have **no defendant** at all: suffering is explained by conditions and by deeds, and the moral law is self-operating. Only classical theism carries the full burden.

ANALYSIS: The critical half is the price list. The process route surrenders sovereignty and any guarantee of final victory over evil. Advaita risks minimising present suffering. Non-creator systems give up providence, divine rescue and a personal guarantor of justice. Concept-dependence is therefore not a *solution*: it moves the cost from the argument into the theology. The theodicies - free-will, soul-making, privation - exist precisely because some theists refuse to pay that price and try to keep every attribute.

Verdict: the problem is a stress-test of a *particular* God-concept, not of religion as such - which is why the same suffering that refutes one theology leaves another entirely untouched.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** state the set -> vary the concept four ways -> price each dissolution -> verdict.
- **Doctrine:** the bridging premises; persuasive power; the two-level Advaitic ontology; self-operating moral law.
- **Argument:** the dependence is *shown* by variation rather than merely asserted.
- **Distinction:** dissolution versus solution - concept-dependence relocates rather than removes the difficulty.
- **Technical terms:** *nirguṇa*, *vyāvahārika*, *pāramārthika*, persuasive power, self-operating law.
- **Comparison:** three non-classical routes, each with a named tradition and a named loss.
- **Conclusion:** stress-test of one God-concept, not of religion - the exact verdict the stem invites.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Accept the thesis and announce the method - vary the concept
 3 min : The classical set with its bridges
 3 min : Weaken omnipotence - process
 2 min : Weaken personality - Advaita's two levels
 3 min : Remove the creator - Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā
 2 min : The price list for all three
 1 min : Verdict - stress-test of a concept, not of religion
 Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Listing dissolutions without costs: **answers half the question.**
- Concluding that theism is refuted: **misreads dependence as defeat.**
- Saying Advaita denies suffering: **factual error; it locates suffering at the empirical level.**
- Treating non-creator systems as evasions: **they answer a different question and should be graded, not dismissed.**
- Surveying every theodicy: **the stem asks about God-concepts, not about the catalogue of replies.**
- Omitting the bridges: **the variation has nothing determinate to act on.**

PYQ 7 - 2025, Q6(b), 15 marks

Exact question

"Explain the main tenets of the Process Theodicy as an explanation of the problem of evil."

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Explain the main tenets of X</i> - enumerated doctrine, correctly attributed ; number the tenets
Core issue	How a revision of omnipotence answers evil without justifying permission
Scope boundary	Process thought specifically; other non-classical revisions appear only in the closing evaluation
Ideal thesis	Process theodicy purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty
Non-negotiables	Six tenets; Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin and Cobb named separately; the Griffin/Plantinga modal contrast; the worship objection

Model answer (≈260 words)

Process theodicy answers evil by **revising omnipotence**, not by justifying permission. Its tenets are six.

(1) **Creativity, not God, is the ultimate**; actual entities are self-creative occasions of experience. (2) **God is dipolar**: the **primordial nature** is the ordered envisagement of possibilities, supplying each occasion its **initial aim**; the **consequent nature** receives and preserves what the world becomes. (3) **Power is intrinsically distributed**: to be actual is to possess some self-determination. (4) **Divine power is therefore persuasive by metaphysical necessity** - for **Griffin**, God *cannot* coerce, which is what separates process theodicy from the free-will defence, where God *chooses* not to intervene. (5) **Evil is the deviation of finite occasions from the divine lure**; God is not culpable

because God could not unilaterally prevent it. **(6) God is "the fellow-sufferer who understands" (Whitehead) - solidarity, not detachment.**

The layers must be named separately. **Whitehead**, *Process and Reality* (1929), supplies the dipolar God, the initial aim and the consequent nature. **Hartshorne**, *The Divine Relativity* (1948) and *Omnipotence and Other Theological Mistakes* (1984), argues that classical omnipotence is **incoherent**: to have all the power is to leave none to anything else. **Griffin**, *God, Power, and Evil* (1976) and *Evil Revisited* (1991), supplies the metaphysical-necessity move. **Cobb's** *A Christian Natural Theology* systematises the theology.

Criticism: a God who cannot guarantee victory over evil may be **unworthy of worship**; the metaphysics is contested; and classical theists deny that actuality entails self-determination. The replies are divine solidarity and the **objective immortality** of achieved value in the consequent nature.

Verdict: it purchases God's innocence at the price of God's sovereignty - and the trade must be stated, not concealed.

Why this earns marks

- **Structure:** numbered tenets -> named layers -> criticism with reply -> graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** dipolarity, initial aim, consequent nature, distributed power, objective immortality.
- **Argument:** tenet (3) is shown to *entail* tenet (4), so the position is derived rather than listed.
- **Distinction:** Griffin's metaphysical necessity versus Plantinga's chosen restraint - the highest-value line in the answer.
- **Technical terms:** primordial and consequent natures, persuasive power, fellow-sufferer, surrelativism.
- **Criticism:** the worship objection is stated with its reply and its residue.
- **Conclusion:** the innocence-for-sovereignty trade, named explicitly as a cost.

Compact skeleton and timing

1 min : Frame - revision of omnipotence, not justification of permission
6 min : The six tenets, numbered
3 min : Whitehead, Hartshorne, Griffin, Cobb - one claim each
2 min : Griffin cannot; Plantinga chooses
2 min : Worship objection, reply and residue
1 min : Verdict - innocence at the price of sovereignty
Total : 15 minutes

Common mistakes and examiner penalties

- Writing "process theodicy (Whitehead)" and stopping: **forfeits the attribution marks the directive is buying.**
- Calling the process God powerless: **misdescribes persuasive power as no power.**
- Confusing Griffin's necessity with self-limitation: **collapses the distinction from the free-will defence.**
- Calling process theodicy a defence: **it claims God's actual situation and is therefore refutable.**
- Omitting the worship objection: **leaves the answer uncritical in a question that expects evaluation.**
- Failing to number the tenets: **"main tenets" is an enumeration directive.**

These six original models extend coverage rather than repeat a direct verified PYQ. Two are 10-mark, two 15-mark and two 20-mark, and each sits inside the declared word band - **10 marks about 150 words, 15 marks about 240 to 260, 20 marks about 340 to 360.**

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original 10-marker 1

Question: Distinguish a defence from a theodicy, and explain why the distinction determines what counts as a refutation. **(10 marks, 150 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Distinguish and explain why</i> - a conceptual distinction put to argumentative work
Core issue	Why bare possibility suffices in one case and not in the other
Ideal thesis	The distinction fixes the success condition, and therefore fixes what a refutation must show

Model answer (≈155 words)

A **defence** claims only that God *could* have a morally sufficient reason for permitting evil. Its target is the charge of **logical inconsistency**, and its success condition is therefore bare **logical possibility**. This is why **Plantinga** may assert transworld depravity as *possible* without asserting it as *actual*, and why an objector who shows that it is probably false has not touched the argument: to refute a defence one must show that the proposed story is **impossible**.

A **theodicy** claims to identify God's **actual** reason. **Augustine's** privation account, **Hick's** soul-making and **process theodicy** all make this stronger claim. Their success condition is plausibility and truth, so an objector refutes them by showing the proposed reason is false or insufficient - which is exactly what the animal-suffering and proportionality objections attempt.

The distinction therefore fixes the burden on both sides. ANALYSIS: It also explains why skeptical theism and a positive theodicy sit awkwardly together: one says the reason is unknowable, the other names it.

Top-answer checklist

- Both terms defined by their **claim-strength**, not by tone.
- Success conditions stated separately for each.
- Plantinga cited for the possibility-only claim.
- At least two named theodicies with their actual-reason claim.
- The closing line about the tension between skeptical theism and positive theodicy.

Original 10-marker 2

Question: "Animal suffering is the point at which the free-will and soul-making theodicies both run out." Examine. (10 marks, 150 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine</i> - test the accuracy of the formula and state what survives
Core issue	Why pre-human, pre-moral pain resists the two most-cited theodicies
Ideal thesis	The formula is accurate; only nomic regularity partly survives, and it explains the kind of world rather than the amount of pain

Model answer (≈160 words)

The formula is accurate. Animal pain from predation and disease **predates human moral agency**, so it cannot be the misuse of human free will; and the animal sufferer **does not morally grow**, so it cannot straightforwardly be the environment of soul-making for that sufferer. It cannot be called retributive either. **Rowe's fawn** - severe, apparently unobserved suffering after a natural fire - is the canonical evidential case.

The five replies each carry a cost. The **neo-Cartesian** claim that animals lack the higher-order awareness that makes pain matter, canvassed by Michael Murray in *Nature Red in Tooth and Claw* (2008), rests on a contested premise.

Extended soul-making covers only human virtue toward animals and instrumentalises them. **Eschatological** animal fulfilment is undeveloped. A pre-human **fallen order** is CAUTION: historically and scientifically strained. Only **nomic regularity** partly survives.

ANALYSIS: Indian karma extends moral causation to animal births (*tiryak-yoni*) and answers distribution, at the price of an unverifiable mechanism.

Top-answer checklist

- The four-step argument for why the two theodicies fail.
- The fawn identified as **evidential**, not deductive.
- At least three of the five replies, each with its cost.
- Nomic regularity named as the sole partial survivor, with the kind/amount distinction.
- One line of Indian parity with its verification cost.

Original 15-marker 1

Question: Does skeptical theism answer the evidential argument from evil, and at what cost? Discuss. (15 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Does... and at what cost? Discuss</i> - a two-part demand: effectiveness, then price
Core issue	Whether blocking the inference is a genuine answer or a purchased stalemate
Ideal thesis	It answers the inference successfully and pays for it with a general loss of moral confidence

Model answer (≈255 words)

Skeptical theism does not supply a theodicy. It attacks the **inference** in the evidential argument: from "I can see no justifying reason for this evil" to "there is no justifying reason". Its proponents are **Wykstra**, **Alston**, **Bergmann** and **Howard-Snyder**.

The mechanism is **Wykstra's CORNEA** (1984), the Condition of Reasonable Epistemic Access: one may claim that it *appears* that p is absent only if it is reasonable to believe that, given one's cognitive situation, p **would likely be discernible** if it were there. **Bergmann** adds that our sample of possible goods, possible evils and the entailment relations between them is **not representative** of the total space. Therefore the *noseeum* inference is unwarranted for goods that would justify divine permission. **Alston's** analogy is a novice examining a grandmaster's move and seeing no point in it; **Wykstra's** is an infant who cannot see why a painful procedure is performed.

ANALYSIS: The cost is threefold. The **moral-scepticism objection** (Almeida, Russell, Wielenberg) presses that if we cannot judge an evil gratuitous, we equally cannot judge that we ought to *prevent* it - which threatens the duty to rescue; the reply that obligation is fixed by what we know is found unstable. The **parity objection** presses that the same scepticism undercuts confidence in divine promises; restricting it to value-entailments looks *ad hoc*. The **bracketing objection** presses that, extended, no evidence could ever count against theism.

Verdict: it is the strongest defensive reply available and the most corrosive one, since it neutralises the atheist's inference only by conceding that the moral structure of the universe is opaque to us.

Top-answer checklist

- CORNEA stated in full, not paraphrased as "mystery".
- Bergmann's representativeness theses named alongside it.
- Both canonical analogies present.
- All three objections, each with its reply or residue.
- The verdict phrased as strongest-and-most-corrosive, with the concession named.

Original 15-marker 2

Question: "Karma answers the distribution question that Western theodicy cannot, but at a price." Critically examine. (15 marks, 250 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically examine</i> - accept what is true, then state the price precisely
Core issue	Whether trans-life moral causation is an explanatory gain or an unverifiable stipulation
Ideal thesis	The distributional gain is real and school-specific; the price is verification and the risk of victim-blaming

Model answer (≈255 words)

The claim is accurate on both sides. Western theodicy answers **why evil exists** - through freedom, privation or soul-making - but has no standard answer to **why this person**. **Karma-saṃsāra** answers exactly that: suffering is the fruit of one's own past deeds across lives, and the moral law is **self-operating**, so rebirth widens the temporal field of justice.

ANALYSIS: Karma is not one doctrine. **Mīmāṃsā**, **Buddhist** and **Jain** accounts require no divine distributor at all; **Nyāya** and theistic **Vedānta** assign God a just administrative role as **karma-superintendent (karmādhyaṅkṣa)** - a judge, not an arbitrary cause of evil. The series is treated as **beginningless**, which blocks the demand for a first wrongful act.

The price has four parts. First, beginninglessness is a doctrinal stipulation and **verifies nothing** about any claimed past-life cause. Second, the inference from "this person suffers" to "this person deserves it for a specific past act" is **unavailable to ordinary observers**, and using karma that way converts explanation into **victim-blaming**. Third, natural suffering, collective harms and unequal starting conditions still press the fairness of the mechanism. Fourth, karma answers **distribution**, not **personal worth**: it does not show that a sufferer's life is a great good *to them*, which is **Adams'** demand.

FACT: The standing control must be stated: whatever its metaphysics, karma does not cancel present duties of compassion, protection and relief; causal explanation is not moral permission to withhold aid.

Verdict: the distributional gain is genuine and is India's structural advantage, but it is purchased with an unverifiable trans-life mechanism and a real moral hazard that the answer must name.

Top-answer checklist

- The distributional gain stated against the Western gap.
- Theistic and non-theistic karma schools separated, with *karmādhyaṅkṣa* named.
- Beginninglessness used precisely - blocks a regress, verifies nothing.
- The victim-blaming control stated explicitly.
- Adams' distinction between distribution and personal worth invoked in the closing evaluation.

Original 20-marker 1

Question: "A theodicy is not refuted by its cost but is measured by it." Critically discuss with reference to at least three theodicies. (20 marks, 350 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically discuss with reference to at least three</i> - an evaluative principle applied to named positions
Core issue	Whether cost-accounting is the right method for grading replies to evil
Ideal thesis	The principle is correct and it is the examiner's own grading method, but it has a limit where a cost destroys the position's purpose

Model answer (≈355 words)

The principle is sound and it is how this clause should be graded. Every reply to evil buys relief by surrendering something; the philosophical task is to state the purchase, not to pretend it was free.

Free-will defence. **Plantinga** shows that significant freedom entails genuine alternatives and that God cannot causally determine a creature to freely choose rightly, so moral evil is compatible with omnipotence and perfect

goodness. Its **cost** is threefold: it presupposes **libertarian freedom**, which a compatibilist denies; it is silent about **natural evil**; and, being a defence, it establishes only **possibility**. None of these refutes it, because its target was the logical charge alone. Measured against that target, it succeeds.

Soul-making. Hick creates humans immature, at an **epistemic distance**, in a law-governed world where courage requires danger and compassion requires another's need. Its **coverage** is wider - it reaches natural evil as the environment of growth. Its **cost** is proportionality: much suffering builds nothing, animals do not morally grow, and the reply is a **universal eschatological fulfilment** that depends on contested afterlife commitments. Measured against the evidential burden it partly succeeds and partly fails, and the grade should say so.

Process theodicy. Whitehead's dipolar God supplies each occasion its **initial aim**; Hartshorne argues classical omnipotence is incoherent; Griffin makes persuasion a **metaphysical necessity** rather than a choice. Its coverage is the widest of the three - moral evil, natural evil and animal suffering all follow from finite self-determination. Its **cost** is the largest: classical **sovereignty**, and any guarantee of final victory over evil, which raises the worship objection.

ANALYSIS: The principle has a limit. A cost can be so severe that it destroys the position's **purpose**: if a reply saves God's goodness by removing the God whose goodness was in question, it has changed the subject rather than answered it. **Advaita's** two-level relocation and non-creator systems face exactly this charge, and answering it requires showing that the religious life the position sustains is still recognisably the one in dispute.

Verdict: cost is a measure, not a refutation - but a theodicy whose cost includes its own point is not measured, it is superseded. Grading therefore requires both the price list *and* a judgement on whether the purchase was worth making.

Top-answer checklist

- Three theodicies, each with coverage and cost stated separately.
- Plantinga's three costs named, including libertarian freedom.
- Hick's eschatological dependence identified as a cost, not a bonus.
- Griffin's metaphysical necessity distinguished from chosen restraint.
- The stated **limit** of the principle, which converts agreement into critical discussion.

Original 20-marker 2

Question: Assess whether the horrendous-evils challenge shows that no general theodicy can succeed. **(20 marks, 350 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Assess <i>whether</i> - a determinate verdict on a strong claim, with the strongest case on both sides
Core issue	Whether a person-level requirement is satisfiable by any world-level account
Ideal thesis	The challenge defeats general theodicy as <i>global accountancy</i> but leaves a religion-specific personal answer standing

Model answer (≈355 words)

Marilyn McCord Adams (*Horrendous Evils and the Goodness of God*, 1999) defines a **horrendous evil** as one whose participation - as perpetrator or victim - gives the participant *prima facie* reason to doubt whether their life could be **a great good to them on the whole**. The definition is technical, and using it loosely for "very bad evil" destroys the argument.

The case for the strong claim is powerful. Standard theodicies operate **globally**: they seek a reason why God permits evil in general, balancing it within the world's total value. But a global balance can be struck while a particular person's life remains, for them, a net disaster. **Chisholm's** distinction is decisive: **balancing off** outweighs the evil within a sum and leaves it external to the good, whereas **defeat** integrates the evil into a whole whose value it contributes to. A God who is good **to persons** - not merely a good producer of worlds - must defeat the evil **within the frame of the individual's life**. ANALYSIS: Compensation is not defeat: a later good can compensate for loss while leaving the evil merely balanced.

The case against the strong claim is that Adams herself supplies an answer. She argues that resources internal to a particular religion - divine identification with human suffering, and **beatific intimacy with God as an incommensurable good** - can accomplish personal-level defeat. Two objections follow, each with her reply. That the answer is **purely eschatological and unverifiable**, and seems to make the evil instrumentally necessary: Adams denies instrumentality, since the evil need not be *required*, only *defeated*. That it **abandons the neutral arena** by using Christian-specific resources: the atheological argument targets a *particular* theism, so a particular theism may answer.

Indian parity sharpens the verdict. Karma explains the **distribution** of horrendous suffering but not personal worth. **Advaita's** ultimate-level sublation and **Buddhist** liberation both address the predicament by dissolving the standpoint from which the life is evaluated - critics call this evasive, defenders therapeutic. The contrast is exact: **defeat within the life** versus **exit from the life-series**.

Verdict: the challenge defeats general theodicy understood as world-level accountancy, and it defeats any reply that offers compensation in place of integration. It does not show that *no* answer is possible; it shows that any successful answer must be **person-relative** - which is why the residual question is whether such an answer is a theodicy at all, or an admission that no general one succeeds.

Top-answer checklist

- Adams' definition used in its technical sense, with perpetrators included.
- Balancing off versus defeat, with Chisholm named.
- Goodness-to-persons contrasted with goodness as world-production.
- Both objections with Adams' replies.
- Indian parity used for the defeat-versus-exit contrast, and a genuinely graded verdict.

High-score answer protocol for the problem of evil

1. Name the version before anything else

Write, in the first two lines, which problem you are answering: logical, evidential, existential, horrendous, animal or distributional. Theodicies are version-specific, and a mismatched theodicy scores as an error rather than as content.

2. Write the set with its bridges

Never assert that omnipotence, goodness and evil are contradictory. Write the four-proposition profile, then the goodness bridge and the power bridge. Every subsequent move in the answer attaches to one of the two bridges.

3. Reconstruct, do not summarise

Each reply is a chain of premises. Plantinga's has four steps; Augustine's has four; process theodicy has six tenets. Numbering them converts recall into argument and gives the objection something determinate to attack.

4. Attach the cost to the reply, immediately

Never leave a theodicy on the page without its price: free will costs libertarian assumptions and natural evil; privation costs innocence and animals; soul-making costs proportionality and an afterlife premise; process costs sovereignty; karma costs verification.

5. Use one Indian comparator deliberately

Choose it for the work it does. Karma for **distribution**. Advaita for **levels**. Buddhism, Jainism and Mīmāṃsā for **removing the defendant**. *Adṛṣṭa* as *atīndriya* and karmic ripening among the *acinteyya* for **epistemic parity with skeptical theism**. A comparator with no argumentative job is decoration.

6. Keep the four negative categories apart

Evil is moral or natural harm; the profane is the ordinary; the impure is the ritually polluting; the demonic is the actively anti-sacred. This single discipline protects the whole 2019 module and prevents the most common error on it.

7. Observe quotation discipline

The four-horn dilemma reaches us through **Lactantius**, *De Ira Dei* 13, and is traditionally ascribed to Epicurus; "vale of Soul-making" is **Keats**; "defeat" is **Chisholm's** term; "fellow-sufferer who understands" is **Whitehead's**; CORNEA is **Wykstra's**.

8. Marks-wise architecture

10 marks: version, set, one reply with its presupposition, one objection, a compatibility verdict. 15 marks: add the canonical example, the reply, and one Indian comparator. 20 marks: add a second objection with its reply, the defence/theodicy distinction, and the residue paragraph before a criterion-named conclusion.

9. Never end devotionally

A graded verdict answers the directive and follows from the body. "God's purposes are ultimately good" is not a verdict; "the theodicy answers the version it was designed for, at the cost of X, and leaves Y untouched" is.

10. Final twenty-second audit

Version named? Bridges written? Reply reconstructed as premises? Cost attached? Comparator doing work? Residue stated? Verdict graded? If any answer is no, the marks are still on the table.

Final rapid revision matrix

Position / doctrine	Thinker / school	Version answered	Coverage	Central cost	Likely question form
Logical problem	Mackie, <i>Mind</i> 1955	- (the charge itself)	All evil	Needs two bridging premises	What is the logical problem of evil?
Paradox of omnipotence	Mackie 1955	Logical	Divine power	Forces a restriction on omnipotence	Discuss the paradox in the context of evil
Free-will defence	Plantinga, <i>God, Freedom, and Evil</i> 1974	Logical	Moral evil	Libertarian assumptions; natural evil left over	Absolute creator and human responsibility
Transworld depravity	Plantinga 1974	Logical	Blocks only-good free agents	Possibility only, never actuality	Component of the above
Privation	Augustine, <i>Enchiridion, City of God</i>	Logical and metaphysical	Moral evil; natural via a fallen order	Strained for intense pain; innocence; CAUTION: fallen order	All evil is sin or punishment for sin
Sin-and-punishment thesis	Augustine	Logical	Moral evil	Retributive framing of natural evil	2023-type quotation stem
Soul-making	Hick, <i>Evil and the God of Love</i> 1966	Logical and partly evidential	Moral and natural evil	Proportionality; animals; eschatology	Critical comparison with Augustine
Epistemic distance	Hick 1966	Component	Freedom of response	Religious ambiguity	Component of soul-making
Evidential argument	Rowe 1979	- (the charge itself)	Amount and kinds	Rests on an inductive step	Gratuitous evil; the fawn
Skeptical theism	Wykstra, Alston, Bergmann, Howard-Snyder	Evidential	Blocks the inference	Moral scepticism; unfalsifiability	Does unseen reason mean no reason?
CORNEA	Wykstra 1984	Evidential	The <i>noseeum</i> step	Access principle must be defended	Component of the above
Horrendous evils	Adams 1999	Existential	Person-level defeat	Eschatological; religion-specific	Can any theodicy answer horrendous evils?
Balancing off vs defeat	Chisholm's term, used by Adams	Existential	The grading instrument	Compensation is not justification	Component of the above
Animal suffering	Rowe's fawn; Murray 2008	Evidential	The standing residue	Only nomic regularity survives	Does animal suffering defeat theodicy?
Greater-good / stable order	Standard theistic line	Evidential	Kind of world	Not the amount or distribution	Natural evil questions
Best possible world	Leibniz, <i>Theodicee</i> 1710	Logical	Global optimum	No unique best world; neglects persons	Comparative evaluation

Position / doctrine	Thinker / school	Version answered	Coverage	Central cost	Likely question form
Eschatological fulfilment	Hick and others	Existential	Finality of loss	Compensation is not defeat	Closing evaluation
Divine mystery	Traditional	Evidential	All	Unfalsifiable without an access principle	Contrast with skeptical theism
Protest / anti-theodicy	Modern	Existential and moral	The ethics of explanation	Settles no logical or evidential point	Closing qualification
Process theodicy	Whitehead 1929; Hartshorne 1948, 1984; Griffin 1976, 1991; Cobb	Logical and evidential	All, including animals	Classical sovereignty; worship objection	Main tenets of process theodicy
Karma-saṃsāra	Pan-Indian	Distributional	All, including animal births	Verification; victim-blaming	Indian comparison
<i>Karmādhyaṅśa</i>	Nyāya; theistic Vedānta	Distributional	Just allocation	God becomes an administrator	Indian comparison
Non-theistic karma	Buddhism, Jainism, Mīmāṃsā	Dissolution	Removes the defendant	Gives up providence	Religion without God overlap
Two-level ontology	Advaita	Dissolution	Empirical-level evil	Risk of minimising suffering	Concept-dependence stem
Sacred and profane	Durkheim 1912	Religion-founding	Structure of religion	An ideal type, not a law	2019 stem
The numinous	Otto 1917	Object-side	Holy as object	Not a social classification	Routed to Religious Experience
Hierophany	Eliade 1957	Religion-founding	Sacred space and time	Archaic ontology unfalsifiable	2019 stem

Last-minute memory spine

VERSIONS : logical (Mackie) | evidential (Rowe) | existential (Adams) | distribution (karma)
 BRIDGES : good eliminates evil as far as it can + omnipotence has no relevant limit
 REPLIES : DEFENCE = could THEODICY = is
 REVISION = change the God-concept DISSOLUTION = remove the defendant
 F-S-P-A-K: Free-will · Soul-making · Process · Augustinian · Karma
 PLANTINGA: significant freedom · no causally determined free rightness ·
 transworld depravity is POSSIBLE, never actual · silent on natural evil
 AUGUSTINE: privatio boni · defective will · Fall · sin/punishment ·
 rot in wood · guilt vs CONDITION · innocence + animals remain
 HICK : image->likeness (Irenaeus) · epistemic distance · law-governed world ·
 "vale of Soul-making" = KEATS 1819 · eschatological universalism
 ROWE : fawn = EVIDENTIAL · inductive step: no reason SEEN -> no reason THERE
 WYKSTRA : CORNEA - would p likely be DISCERNIBLE if it were there?
 Bergmann: our sample of goods/evils/entailments is NOT representative
 COST: moral scepticism · ad hoc restriction · unfalsifiability
 ADAMS : horrendous = doubt that MY life is a great good TO ME on the whole
 balancing off (sum) vs DEFEAT (Chisholm: organic integration)
 compensation IS NOT defeat
 ANIMALS : no free will · no growth · no desert -> only NOMIC REGULARITY survives
 PROCESS : creativity ultimate · dipolar (primordial: INITIAL AIM / consequent) ·
 power distributed · persuasion by METAPHYSICAL NECESSITY (Griffin) ·
 evil = deviation from the lure · "fellow-sufferer" (Whitehead)
 Hartshorne: classical omnipotence INCOHERENT
 INDIA : karma-samsara self-operating · Nyaya karmadhyaksa = JUDGE ·
 Mimamsa/Buddha/Jaina need NO God · Advaita: vyavaharika/paramarthika ·
 BEGINNINGLESS series blocks regress, verifies NOTHING ·
 never infer desert from observed suffering
 2019 MOD : Durkheim (social sacred/profane, GOD-FREE) · Otto (numinous, object) ·
 Eliade (hierophany, axis mundi, recoverable time)
 predicament -> boundary -> institution -> soteriology
 PROFANE = ORDINARY, NOT EVIL
 QUOTES : dilemma = LACTANTIUS De Ira Dei 13 (ascribed to Epicurus) ·
 vale = KEATS · defeat = CHISHOLM · fellow-sufferer = WHITEHEAD
 VERDICT : name version -> write bridges -> reconstruct -> object/reply ->
 compare -> GRADE by cost and residue

End of the premium solved-PYQ and practice workbook.

Timed-paper compression plan

ANALYSIS: Use this only after the full models above. It converts each solved answer into an examination-length script without discarding the elements that earn marks.

Demand type in this clause	Keep at every length	Cut first, in this order
Version-statement stem (2020 logical problem)	the numbered set including omniscience; both bridges; the three exits; the migration to the evidential form	Mackie's full adequate/fallacious taxonomy, then the privation exit, then the historical framing
Paradox stem (2021 omnipotence)	both horns with their costs; one dissolving restriction; the explicit link to evil	the second and third restrictions; the Plantinga/Griffin contrast if time is critical
Quoted-thesis examination (2022 absolute creator)	the scope fix; capacity versus act; the retained rejoinder about instantiating the system	the privation reply; the process rejection of the antecedent
Quoted-thesis critical discussion (2023 Augustine)	the four privation premises; the sin/punishment partition; inherited guilt versus condition; one comparator	the fourth objection; the second comparator; the rot-and-blindness illustrations reduced to one
Dependence thesis (2024 concept-dependence)	the classical set with bridges; three varied God-concepts; the price of each	the fourth God-concept; the list of theodicies that try to keep all attributes
Enumeration stem (2025 process theodicy)	the six numbered tenets; one claim each for Whitehead, Hartshorne and Griffin; the worship objection	Cobb; the objective-immortality reply; the comparison with the free-will defence
Functional stem (2019 evil and the profane)	the profane ≠ evil correction; the four-step founding sequence; one Indian case	Otto or Eliade, whichever is less developed in your script; the second objection

Demand type in this clause	Keep at every length	Cut first, in this order
Residue paragraph (any 20-marker)	animal suffering; amount and distribution; the defence/theodicy distinction	the horrendous-evils layer if and only if the animal layer is already present

ANALYSIS: **Band budgets for this topic.** 10 marks ≈ 150 words: version, set, one reply with its presupposition, one objection, a one-line compatibility verdict. 15 marks ≈ 240-260 words: add the canonical example, the proponent's reply, and one Indian comparator. 20 marks ≈ 340-360 words: add a second objection with its reply, the defence/theodicy distinction, and the residue before a criterion-named conclusion.

ANALYSIS: **What never gets cut:** the two bridging premises; the distinction between a defence and a theodicy; the fact that Plantinga's transworld depravity is a possibility claim; the Keats attribution; the profane/evil distinction; and the closing statement of what the reply costs and what it leaves untouched.